AFRICAN SOLIDARITY CIVIC ORGANISATION (ASCO)
Registered NPC: 2026/521895/08
SARS Approved PBO: 930092287

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CORPORATE CSI PARTNERSHIP PROPOSAL

Sappi Southern Africa × ASCO

EcoStudy Community Stewardship: Learners and Communities for Biodiversity, Water and Sustainable Living

Requested CSI investment: R150,000

Proposed implementation area: Communities and public schools near Saiccor Mill, KwaZulu-Natal, subject to Sappi confirmation of geographic fit, community consent and site permissions.

Prepared: October 2026

Confidential proposal for corporate CSI / ESG consideration. This document presents a proposed partnership and does not represent an award, endorsement, existing partnership or company commitment.

Executive summary

ASCO is seeking a strategic corporate CSI partnership with **Sappi Southern Africa** to support a measurable public-benefit initiative: **EcoStudy Community Stewardship: Learners and Communities for Biodiversity, Water and Sustainable Living**. The proposed request is **R150,000**, to be applied to direct programme delivery, participation access, safety, learning materials, monitoring and accountable reporting.

ASCO is approved to issue Section 18A receipts effective 9 October 2026. Receipts may be issued only for qualifying donations used solely for the approved Section 18A activities: human rights and democracy, and family stability.

> **The proposal in one sentence:** EcoStudy Community Stewardship: Learners and Communities for Biodiversity, Water and Sustainable Living in Communities and public schools near Saiccor Mill, KwaZulu-Natal, subject to Sappi confirmation of geographic fit, community consent and site permissions., benefiting Proposed: public-school learners and educators, with secondary participation by parents, community volunteers and local environmental/community organisations in selected communities near Saiccor Mill. Final numbers and beneficiary selection should follow a verified baseline and local consultation. through a locally designed, monitored and reportable intervention aligned with Sappi Southern Africa's publicly documented priorities, subject to the company's confirmation of eligibility and application requirements.

What ASCO is requesting
R150,000 in CSI support, or a partial/in-kind contribution structured with the company.

What the funding would enable
Direct activities, participation access, safe delivery, community materials, monitoring and a close-out report.

About ASCO

ASCO is a community-focused civic organisation promoting social justice, community development, active citizenship, African unity, environmental sustainability, inclusion and sustainable public-benefit action. ASCO works through advocacy, education, grassroots initiatives, humanitarian and community-development activities, partnerships and practical interventions.

ASCO is governed by four Directors. The Board governs and Executive Management manages. ASCO maintains governance, donation, safeguarding, financial-management, data-protection, monitoring and reporting instruments for responsible partnership administration.

ASCO's primary contact for this proposal is:

Mr. Bhekisisa (Mdu) Shandu
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The proposed project

Project title
EcoStudy Community Stewardship: Learners and Communities for Biodiversity, Water and Sustainable Living

Implementation period
Proposed 6–12 month pilot, with final schedule agreed after eligibility, baseline and permissions are confirmed.

Location
Communities and public schools near Saiccor Mill, KwaZulu-Natal, subject to Sappi confirmation of geographic fit, community consent and site permissions.

Target beneficiaries
Proposed: public-school learners and educators, with secondary participation by parents, community volunteers and local environmental/ community organisations in selected communities near Saiccor Mill. Final numbers and beneficiary selection should follow a verified baseline and local consultation.

Proposed outputs and targets

The following are proposed planning targets, not completed results. Final targets should be agreed with the company after baseline assessment, budget confirmation and any required stakeholder permissions.

- Proposed: co-design and deliver an environmental-awareness curriculum covering biodiversity, water stewardship, waste reduction and sustainable development for an agreed cohort of schools.
- Proposed: train an agreed number of educators and youth/community facilitators to continue environmental learning after the project period.
- Proposed: complete learner-led environmental audits and practical rehabilitation or biodiversity actions at participating school/community sites, with before-and-after documentation.
- Proposed: establish or strengthen environmental stewardship clubs and run community learning events, with attendance and participation registers.
- Proposed: provide a close-out report with verified reach, activities, lessons, safeguarding compliance and photographs/consents where permitted; all quantities and targets to be agreed with Sappi after baseline assessment.

Expected outcomes

- Improved community participation and practical public-benefit action in the selected location.
- Improved access to relevant learning, environmental, inclusion, humanitarian or youth-development support, depending on the project design.
- Documented implementation evidence, beneficiary participation and lessons for continuation or scale-up.
- Clear accountability through expenditure records, activity updates, monitoring information and a close-out report.

Why this matters

The proposed intervention responds to a community-development need through the sequence **community need → practical intervention → measurable result**. The final baseline will verify the

specific need, beneficiary profile, site conditions, permissions and appropriate indicators before implementation.

ASCO will avoid overstating the problem or claiming results in advance. Where waste, participation, learning, environmental condition, referrals or other outputs are measurable, ASCO will use simple evidence tools such as attendance registers, baseline/endline checks, activity logs, photographs with consent, beneficiary feedback and expenditure records.

> **Evidence discipline:** All numbers in this proposal are either company-reported context from official sources or clearly labelled ASCO planning targets. No completed result, partnership or funding commitment is claimed.

Why Sappi Southern Africa?

ASCO is approved to issue Section 18A receipts effective 9 October 2026. Receipts may be issued only for qualifying donations used solely for the approved Section 18A activities: human rights and democracy, and family stability.

Verified company context

- Sappi identifies environmental social-impact priorities in South Africa including EcoStudy, the Sappi Trails Programme, nature reserves, conservation of rare/threatened/endangered species and water stewardship.
- Sappi says EcoStudy supports communities near its South African mills by providing environmental and sustainable-development education, linking biodiversity conservation to learners' lives and practical rehabilitation of school and community environments.
- Sappi Southern Africa is headquartered in Johannesburg and manages Sappi Paper and Paper Packaging, Sappi Pulp and Sappi Forests; its South African footprint includes four mills: Tugela, Ngodwana, Saiccor and Stanger.
- Sappi states that its South Africa footprint in rural areas, arising from the location of forests and mills, informs its community-development focus. Its published South Africa priorities include water stewardship, sustainable forestry, biodiversity, climate action, circular economy and community development.
- Sappi's social-impact page describes Sappi Khulisa as a South African rural-community and forestry-value-chain programme and lists education, youth and skills development, environment, community development and enterprise development as focus areas.
- The official Sappi contact form offers a General enquiry route and allows selection of South Africa and Sustainability; no dedicated external CSI grant or sponsorship application route was identified in the reviewed official sources.

Company facts are drawn from official sources reviewed for this proposal. They describe public priorities or reported company activity; they are not promises of funding to ASCO.

Indicative project budget

The requested amount is allocated transparently across delivery and accountability categories. The budget is indicative and should be refined with the company after the implementation site, beneficiary profile, quotations and eligible-cost rules are confirmed.

Budget category	Indicative amount	Use
Direct programme implementation	R90,000	Core activities, local delivery inputs and community implementation for the proposed project.
Participant transport and access	R12,000	Reasonable access support to enable participation, subject to eligibility and records.
Safety equipment and participant welfare	R9,000	PPE, first aid, safeguarding, water/refreshments and safe participation requirements.
Educational and mobilisation materials	R12,000	Learning resources, community mobilisation and accessible communication.
Monitoring, evaluation and reporting	R10,500	Baseline, attendance, outcome tracking, documentation and close-out reporting.
Volunteer/project coordination	R10,500	Scheduling, volunteer support, stakeholder coordination and implementation management.
Reasonable administration	R6,000	Reasonable project administration directly attributable to delivery; no inflated overheads.
Total requested CSI investment	**R150,000**	**Equals the proposed request.**

Administration is limited to a reasonable project share. ASCO will not promise audited financial statements unless they are available; it will provide appropriate project expenditure records and supporting documentation.

Partnership options

Option A — Full project funding
Company funds the proposed project at R150,000, subject to approval and agreement.

Option B — Partial project funding
Company contributes a defined portion of the budget, with scope and outputs adjusted transparently.

Option C — Multi-phase partnership
Company supports a pilot followed by an agreed continuation or scale-up phase based on evidence.

In-kind or technical support
Where relevant, equipment, expertise, access or employee volunteering may complement cash support, subject to written agreement.

Accountability and reporting

ASCO will maintain appropriate records relating to funded activities and can provide, subject to agreed requirements:

- Project implementation updates
- Expenditure records and supporting documentation
- Attendance and participation information where appropriate and lawfully collected
- Photographs and activity evidence with appropriate consent
- Safeguarding and incident records where relevant
- Monitoring and outcome information
- Activity and close-out reports

ASCO will agree reporting frequency, eligible costs, procurement expectations, data protection, branding, acknowledgement and any site-access or technical requirements before implementation. Any use of company branding or recognition will be subject to written approval.

Initial contact route

Use Sappi's official Contact Us General enquiry form: https://www.sappi.com/en-us/contact-us; select South Africa and Sustainability and describe the proposed R150,000 environmental-awareness project. The reviewed official sources did not provide a dedicated external CSI application route. Sappi's published skills-centre email (skillscentre@sappi.com) relates to its Skills Centres and should not be treated as a CSI proposal channel unless Sappi redirects the enquiry.

ASCO welcomes an initial discussion to confirm whether the proposed project is within the company's current CSI/ESG remit, whether unsolicited proposals are accepted, what documents are required, and whether the full, partial or in-kind partnership option is most suitable.

Important conditions and open questions

- Sappi's official pages reviewed do not state that unsolicited CSI proposals are accepted, provide a CSI funding ceiling, or confirm eligibility rules for external NGOs; obtain written confirmation before preparing a final budget or proposal.
- The official sources do not confirm that Sappi would fund work outside communities near its operations, nor that it would fund a project in the recommended location.
- Section 18A receipts may be issued only for qualifying donations used solely for ASCO?s two approved Section 18A activities: human rights and democracy, and family stability. This proposal does not represent a completed donation or tax deduction.
- Any use of Sappi branding, employee volunteering, site access, learner data, environmental claims or monitoring methodology would require prior written approval and appropriate safeguarding, permissions and baseline verification.
- The Sappi social-impact page reports existing initiatives and outcomes, but those facts should not be presented as outcomes of the proposed ASCO project.

These cautions are included to prevent overstatement. They should be resolved with the company before ASCO treats the proposal as eligible or finalises a submission budget.

Closing

ASCO believes meaningful social and environmental progress is achieved through collaboration between communities, civil society and responsible corporate partners. We invite **Sappi Southern Africa** to join us in delivering measurable public-benefit impact through a carefully scoped and accountable partnership.

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Official sources and verification links

Important company and programme information in this proposal was checked against the following official sources:

1. https://www.sappi.com/en-gb/sustainable-purpose/social-impact
2. https://www.sappi.com/en-us/about-us/sappi-southern-africa
3. https://www.sappi.com/en-za/insights/articles/our-sustainability-targets-thriving-world
4. https://mediahub.sappi.com/m/7af1e2acee8d6599/original/2024-Sappi-Southern-Africa-Corporate-Citizenship-Report.pdf
5. https://www.sappi.com/en-us/contact-us

Source review and proposal preparation date: October 2026. Company information and application routes can change; ASCO should confirm current requirements before submission.